enable us to put satellites in space which are useful to us in a number of ways. Our country has effective rocket technology and has applied it successfully to provide so many space services globally.

8.1.1 Parts of Rockets

A rocket is a space vehicle with a very powerful engine designed to carry people or equipment beyond Earth and out into the space. There are four major parts or systems in a rocket. They are:

- Structural system
- Payload system
- Guidance system
- Propulsion system

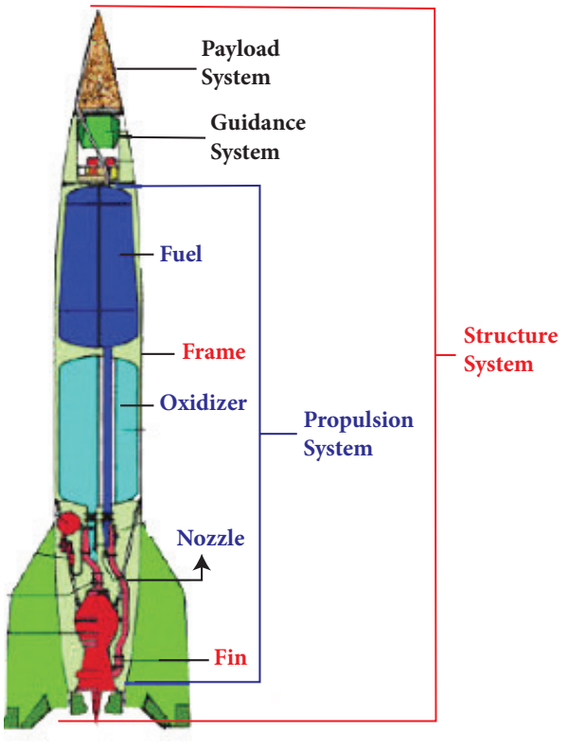


Figure 8.1 Parts of a rocket

Structural system (Frame)

The structural system is the frame that covers the rocket. It is made up of very strong but light weight materials like titanium or aluminum. Fins are attached to some rockets at the bottom of the frame to provide stability during the flight.

Payload system

Payload is the object that the satellite is carrying into the orbit. Payload depends on the rocket's mission. The rockets are modified to launch satellites with a wide range of missions like communications, weather monitoring, spying, planetary exploration, and as observatories. Special rockets are also developed to launch people into the Earth's orbit and onto the surface of the Moon.

Guidance system

Guidance system guides the rocket in its path. It may include sensors, on-board computers, radars, and communication equipments.

Propulsion system

It takes up most of the space in a rocket. It consists of fuel (propellant) tanks, pumps and a combustion chamber. There are two main types of propulsion systems. They are: liquid propulsion system and solid propulsion system.

DO YOU KNOW?

Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV) and Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle (GSLV) rockets are India's popular rockets.

Activity 1

Make a model of a rocket using the low cost materials available to you. Also prepare an album of the rockets launched by India.

8.1.2 Types of Propellants

A propellant is a chemical substance that can undergo combustion to produce pressurized gases whose energy is utilized to move a rocket against the gravitational force of attraction. It is a mixture, which contains a fuel that burns and an oxidizer which supplies the oxygen necessary for the burning (combustion) of the fuel. The propellants may be in the form of a solid or liquid.

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